between the two neighbours and saw the launch of the Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India (TAPI) pipeline despite a grim security situation.[14]

'(Nice) Big brother is here to stay'

Not a single pen had moved from its place in the Indian embassy complex in Kabul, which had been abandoned in a rush in September 1996.[15] While dust accumulated in the deserted embassy compound, the Taliban had been using the Indian ambassador's residence in Wazir Akbar Khan, and had not bothered clearing it of ammunition before escaping the UF military onslaught after 9/11.[16] Given the scale of Kabul's destruction during the civil war, the embassy complex was in surprisingly good shape, allowing Lambah to confidently announce that after fixing the '*pani* [water], *bijli* [electricity], and telephone connections'; the embassy would begin issuing visas within two weeks.[17] Despite the Bonn compromise, the Kunduz airlift, and exclusion from Afghanistan's security sector, New Delhi rapidly expanded its profile in the humanitarian and development sectors in Afghanistan. The aim was to reconnect with Afghanistan both at the elite and the community level by using India's growing economic capabilities. Consulates in Jalalabad, Kandahar, Mazar-e-Sharif, and Herat were opened to manage India's developmental projects and political presence across the country (and to track Pakistani activities in Afghanistan).[18]

Divided into four broad areas, India's aid to Afghanistan covered humanitarian assistance, big infrastructural projects, small development projects (SDPs), education, and capacity development.[19] Cumulatively, India committed US$ 2.3 billion as aid in the years after the US intervention. This included building the Zaranj-Delaram highway connecting west Afghanistan to Iran's Chahbahar port via the border town of Milak in Sistan-Baluchistan (US$ 150 million), the parliament building in Kabul (US$ 178 million committed and US$ 28 million spent), the 42 megawatt Salma dam on the Hari Rud river in Herat (US$ 130 million), and installing a power transmission line between Pul-e-Khumri and Kabul (US$ 120 million) in collaboration with the Asian Development Bank, among other projects.[20] The Steel Authority of India Ltd (SAIL), a public sector industrial undertaking, secured mining rights at